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Master Thesis Proposal

Developing A Framework and Roadmap for Adapting B2C Customer Acquisition to AI- Mediated Discovery

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1 Background and Motivation

The rapid diffusion of generative artificial intelligence is beginning to reshape how consumers discover, evaluate, and select products and services in digital environments. For many years, customer acquisition in B2C businesses has relied on relatively stable channels such as search engines, social media platforms, app stores, online marketplaces, and paid advertising. Through these channels, firms could influence discovery using established levers such as search visibility, advertising spend, promotional campaigns, and brand communication. However, the emergence of AI-enabled discovery tools such as ChatGPT and Gemini are changing this logic. Consumers are increasingly using conversational AI systems to compare alternatives, summarize information, and support purchase decisions. Recent data indicates the scale of this shift: Google's share of combined information discovery fell from 89.3 percent to 57.6 percent between December 2022 and December 2025, while AI assistants now generate sessions equivalent to approximately 56 percent of global search engine volume ([SparkToro, 2025](#)).

This shift is strategically important because customer acquisition depends not only on product quality or brand strength, but also on being visible and persuasive at the point of discovery. Organic click-through rates have been shown to drop by as much as 61 percent when an AI-generated summary appears in search results, even for pages ranked in position one ([SeoClarity, 2024](#)). Firms may need to compete not only for human attention, but also for inclusion in AI-generated recommendations and AI-mediated consideration sets. As a result, new questions emerge regarding discoverability, control over customer access, and the future relevance of existing acquisition strategies.

Existing approaches mainly focus on channel optimization, campaign performance, and conversion management. Against this backdrop, the present study is motivated by the need to understand how B2C brands respond to a changing acquisition environment in which AI increasingly shapes discovery. The study seeks to examine the emerging challenges associated with AI-mediated discovery, the strategic responses adopted by firms, and the implications for growth, customer relationships, and competitive positioning in B2C markets.

2 Objectives

This thesis aims to develop an actionable framework and roadmap for adapting B2C customer acquisition to AI-mediated discovery. As consumers increasingly use AI-based tools to search, compare, and evaluate products and services, firms may need to rethink traditional acquisition strategies. The study therefore seeks to generate primary empirical insights into the challenges this shift creates for B2C firms and to translate these insights into a practically applicable managerial output.

The specific objectives of the thesis are as follows:

- **Review existing literature** on customer acquisition, digital consumer behavior, AI-mediated discovery, and emerging research on AI-driven changes in search and evaluation processes in order to establish the theoretical foundation of the study.
- **Collect primary empirical data** from practitioners in B2C firms to understand how AI-mediated discovery is perceived and how it is affecting customer acquisition activities in practice.
- **Identify key strategic challenges** that B2C firms face when traditional customer acquisition mechanisms are affected by AI-mediated discovery, particularly with regard to discoverability, customer access, and competitive visibility.
- **Develop an actionable managerial framework** that structures the main dimensions firms should consider when responding to AI-mediated discovery in customer acquisition.
- **Derive an implementation roadmap** that supports B2C firms in applying the framework and translating it into practical strategic action.

3 Research Questions

The present study seeks to examine how B2C firms can adapt customer acquisition to AI-mediated discovery and how this challenge can be translated into practical managerial guidance. In order to address this objective, the study is guided by the following research questions:

Q1. What competitive disadvantages and strategic risks can arise for B2C firms if customer acquisition is not adapted to AI-mediated discovery?

Q2. How do practitioners in B2C firms currently perceive and respond to these challenges?

Q3. Which strategic capabilities and response mechanisms are most relevant for adapting customer acquisition to AI-mediated discovery?

Q4. How can these insights be translated into an actionable framework and implementation roadmap for B2C firms?

4 Literature Review

4.1 Customer Acquisition in B2C Markets

Customer acquisition has long been a central concern in B2C markets because it directly shapes growth, market share, and long-term customer value. In digital environments, acquisition has traditionally depended on channels such as search engines, social media, online marketplaces, app stores, and paid advertising. Prior research on internet-based platform firms also treats customer acquisition as one of the core dimensions of customer management, alongside retention and governance, showing that acquisition is not merely a marketing activity but a strategic capability tied to platform growth and competitive positioning.

As digital channels matured, firms increasingly optimized acquisition through targeting, visibility, conversion management, and digital marketing capability. Conceptual work on digital marketing capability highlights that firms gain advantage not only from using channels, but from developing integrated capabilities around data, content, technology, and customer understanding. This literature provides an important baseline for the present study: customer acquisition in B2C settings has historically been shaped by a relatively stable logic in which firms compete for consumer attention within known digital infrastructures.

4.2 Digital Consumer Discovery and Decision-Making

A second relevant stream of literature examines how consumers search for information, compare options, and form purchase decisions in digital environments. Studies of online customer journeys show that information-channel usage varies across product categories and consumer goals, but consistently demonstrate that search and discovery are decisive stages in the path to purchase. This literature is useful because it shows that customer acquisition is not only about attracting traffic; it also depends on how consumers construct consideration sets and evaluate alternatives before purchase. More recent work on customer journey value reinforces this point by arguing that value is created not only through the final transaction, but through the broader journey-based experience for both the customer and the firm. In other words, discovery is already recognized in the literature as a strategically important stage of market interaction.

4.3 AI in Consumer Search and Discovery

A newer body of work focuses on the role of artificial intelligence in customer experience, search, recommendation, and evaluation. A recent systematic literature review on AI and customer experience shows that AI is increasingly embedded across the customer journey, influencing personalization, service, and decision support. At the same time, research on recommender systems demonstrates that the design of information cues affects how consumers balance recommendations with their own search behavior, suggesting that AI-supported interfaces do not simply present information neutrally; they actively shape how consumers evaluate options.

The emerging managerial literature goes a step further by arguing that AI is becoming a new intermediary in the discovery process itself. McKinsey describes AI-powered search as a “new front door to the internet,” reporting that a substantial share of consumers now intentionally use AI-powered search tools to support buying decisions. Its more recent work on agentic commerce further suggests that AI is already influencing what consumers buy by narrowing the field of options, even if fully autonomous purchasing is still developing.

4.4 Strategic Implications for B2C Firms

The shift toward AI-mediated discovery has significant strategic implications for B2C firms because traditional customer acquisition mechanisms may become less effective in environments where AI systems increasingly influence visibility, comparison, and recommendation. As AI begins to shape early-stage consumer decision-making, firms may no longer be able to rely solely on established acquisition levers such as search visibility, paid promotion, and platform presence. Instead, they may need to adapt to a setting in which discoverability is partly determined by machine-mediated interpretation and recommendation.

This development creates new strategic and managerial challenges for B2C firms. In particular, firms may need to rethink how product and brand information is structured, how trust and relevance are communicated in AI-mediated environments, and how customer access can be maintained when discovery increasingly occurs outside firm-controlled channels. In addition, firms may require new capabilities to monitor changing discovery dynamics, respond to shifts in

acquisition effectiveness, and coordinate strategic adaptation across functions such as marketing, content, product, and digital strategy.

Taken together, these developments suggest that AI-mediated discovery is not only a technological change, but also a strategic challenge that may require new forms of managerial response. For B2C firms, the key issue is no longer only understanding that discovery is changing, but also determining how customer acquisition should be adapted in practice. This points to the need for a more structured and actionable approach to strategic response.

4.5 Research Gap

Taken together, the literature highlights four important points. First, customer acquisition in B2C markets has traditionally relied on established digital channels and related firm capabilities. Second, discovery and evaluation represent critical stages in the digital customer journey. Third, AI is increasingly influencing customer experience, recommendation, and search behavior. Fourth, recent industry and managerial research suggests that AI-mediated discovery may reshape how firms are found, compared, and evaluated in digital markets.

However, a clear research gap remains. Existing academic literature provides valuable insights into digital consumer behavior, recommender systems, and AI-enabled customer experience, but there is still limited understanding of how B2C firms should adapt customer acquisition when discovery itself becomes increasingly AI-mediated. In particular, the current literature offers only limited empirically grounded and practically applicable guidance for managers facing this shift. Much of the most recent discussion is still emerging from consulting and industry analysis, while structured academic work on managerial adaptation remains underdeveloped.

Therefore, there is a need for research that not only examines the strategic challenges created by AI-mediated discovery, but also translates practitioner insights into actionable managerial guidance. This study seeks to address that gap by collecting primary empirical data from B2C practitioners and using these insights to develop a framework and roadmap for adapting customer acquisition to AI-mediated discovery.

5 Methodology

5.1 Research Approach

This thesis follows a qualitative, exploratory, and applied research approach. The qualitative orientation is appropriate because the study seeks to understand how practitioners in B2C firms perceive and respond to the challenges that AI-mediated discovery creates for customer acquisition. Given that the phenomenon is still emerging and remains only partially addressed in academic literature, an exploratory design is suitable for capturing practitioner perspectives, identifying recurring patterns, and uncovering relevant strategic capabilities and response mechanisms.

At the same time, the study is applied in character, as it aims not only to examine an emerging managerial problem but also to develop a practically relevant output. On the basis of primary empirical data, the thesis seeks to derive an actionable framework and implementation roadmap that can support B2C firms in adapting customer acquisition strategies to AI-mediated discovery.

5.2 Research Design

This thesis employs a qualitative research design based on semi-structured expert interviews. The design is suitable because the study addresses an emerging managerial phenomenon and seeks to capture practitioner perspectives on the challenges, responses, and capability requirements associated with AI-mediated discovery in B2C customer acquisition.

Semi-structured expert interviews provide the flexibility to explore individual experiences and interpretations in depth while also allowing for a systematic comparison across participants. This is particularly relevant for the present study, as the objective is not only to understand how practitioners interpret the issue, but also to identify recurring patterns that can be synthesized into a practically applicable framework and roadmap.

5.3 Data Collection

This research will rely on primary empirical data gathered through semi structured interviews with experts. The target participants will be professionals working in customer acquisition, growth, performance marketing, or digital strategy roles at e-commerce and similar B2C firms. These roles

are directly involved in customer acquisition and are most likely to be affected by changes in AI mediated discovery. The study will use purposive sampling to select participants who have relevant professional experience and real exposure to customer acquisition challenges in digital markets. The intended sample consists of about 8 to 10 interviews which is considered appropriate for identifying recurring themes and patterns in an exploratory qualitative study. Participants will be recruited through professional networks and LinkedIn. Interviews will be held online. Each interview is expected to last about 30 to 45 minutes and it will follow a semi structured interview guide covering perceived changes in customer discovery and emerging acquisition challenges and current firm responses and strategic capabilities. The study will ensure informed consent, voluntary participation, confidentiality, and appropriate anonymization of interview data.

5.4 Data Analysis

The primary empirical data collected through the interviews will be analysed using thematic analysis, following the six-phase approach outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006). This approach is suitable because it allows for the systematic identification of recurring themes, patterns, and relationships within qualitative data. In the context of this study, thematic analysis will be used to examine how practitioners perceive the challenges of AI-mediated discovery, how they currently respond to these challenges, and which capabilities and strategic actions they consider most relevant. The analysis will proceed in several steps. First, the interview transcripts will be reviewed and coded in order to identify relevant statements and recurring issues. Second, these initial codes will be grouped into broader themes, such as strategic challenges, capability gaps, response mechanisms, and organizational requirements. Third, the emerging themes will be consolidated into higher-level dimensions that can support the development of the managerial framework.

6 Expected Outcomes

This study is expected to generate primary empirical insights into how B2C practitioners perceive and respond to the strategic challenges created by AI-mediated discovery in customer acquisition. On this basis, the thesis will identify recurring patterns in firm-level challenges, capability requirements, and strategic responses across digitally mediated B2C markets.

The main outcome will be the development of the AI Customer Acquisition Adaptation Framework, a structured managerial tool that organises the key dimensions B2C firms need to address when adapting customer acquisition to AI-mediated discovery. An implementation roadmap will accompany the framework to support the translation of findings into practical managerial action.

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